



Rare blemish: Despite Carlsen's commanding performance, both Praggnanandhaa and Erigaisi managed to challenge the champion, with Erigaisi delivering Carlsen's sole defeat of the tournament.

Kasparov, who dismissed the match as unworthy of the Championship title, Carlsen offered a different perspective.

"They qualified for the World Chess Championship match, and they are deserving of being there. The World Championship in the past has very often been the contest to determine who the best player in the world is, but it has not always been that way, and the fact that it may not be this time just is the kind of way it is. As a chess fan, it is a great spectacle regardless."

A staunch advocate for creativity on the chessboard, Carlsen has been championing freestyle chess, a variant that eliminates reliance on opening theory. The format, inspired by Bobby Fischer's vision, excites Carlsen far more than traditional classical chess.

"I'm very excited about the future of freestyle. The idea itself of sitting down at the chessboard and thinking for a long time does not bore me — that's not the reason why I'm not into standard and classical chess so much. It's more about the preparation and the difficulty of actually getting inside the game.

"But when you play freestyle, you're guaranteed that because there's no opening theory. So we've got a lot of tournaments coming up next year. I am playing Fabiano Caruana in Singapore as an exhibition, so hopefully that will be fun. I believe, not only for myself but also for other top players, it is a format that everyone is excited about."

HOW THE TOURNAMENT UNFOLDED

Upsetting Carlsen in a game is a monumental feat. Beating him in a tournament to claim the title ahead of the all-time great? That's an even taller order.

Although Erigaisi managed the former — stunning Carlsen in a blitz round at Tata Steel — stopping the

Norwegian maestro's storm proved impossible as Carlsen swept both the rapid and blitz events. In his second appearance at this marquee event in India, Carlsen mirrored his 2019 performance, leaving Kolkata with two titles in hand.

A masterclass in Kolkata

At the stunning new venue of Dhono Dhanyo Auditorium in Kolkata — a city renowned for its passionate love of sports — Carlsen found himself in a unique spotlight. Chess took centre stage as a spectator sport, and the crowd's admiration for the 33-year-old legend was discernible.

After a slow start, where Praggnanandhaa and Sarin held him to draws, Carlsen shifted gears. The four-time World Rapid Champion unleashed a ruthless streak, dismantling some of the brightest talents in chess — including Vincent Keymer, Daniil Dubov, Erigaisi, Vidit Gujrathi, S.L. Narayanan, and Wesley So. Seven consecutive wins followed, sealing his triumph in emphatic fashion. In blitz, the time controls may have changed, but the outcome